

PRIVILEGES UNDER Tang rule



▲ Female attendant

Pairs of terra-cotta figures depicting spirits, guardians, and officials stood at the doors of Tang burial chambers. This figurine from a woman's tomb was one of a 9th-century pair representing court ladies-in-waiting.

CHINA'S GOLDEN AGE

The Tang Dynasty (618–907 CE) is often called a golden age of Chinese civilization. During this period, women, particularly elites, enjoyed many rights and privileges, and they played a major political role. The most notable was Empress Wu, the only reigning female emperor in Chinese history, who ruled under titles such as Sacred and Divine Empress Regnant from 690–705.

Women could wield great influence at the imperial capital of Chang'an (now known as Xi'an). In the early 8th century, imperial princesses had the right to independently establish their own offices of staff, which could be highly lucrative. Princess Anle, Empress Wu's granddaughter, sold off over 1,400 appointments at court and in addition fraudulently ordained 12,000 monks and priests. Part of the proceeds may have gone toward an extensive pleasure park she constructed for herself, which featured an artificial lake with a circumference of 16 miles (250 km). Excesses such as Anle's may have led to the imperial austerity edict of 714, which forbade women at court from wearing rich brocades, embroidery, pearls, or jade.

A number of less fortunate women became part of the "Flank Court," which was made up of relatives of men sentenced to death for rebellion. They were responsible for looking after the imperial mulberry trees and making silk.

Many women received an education and some became renowned scholars—the most famous was Shangguan Wan'er (664–710 CE), who organized and judged poetry contests, as well as being one of Empress Wu's



"A CHILD ... **WITH HEAVENLY GRACES** ... WAS CHOSEN ONE DAY **FOR THE IMPERIAL HOUSEHOLD.**"

BAI JUYI ON YANG GUIFEI, ONE OF THE GREAT BEAUTIES OF TANG CHINA

